

木漏れ日

タイム・ヒツキ





Komorebi

木漏れ日

木

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日

Noun

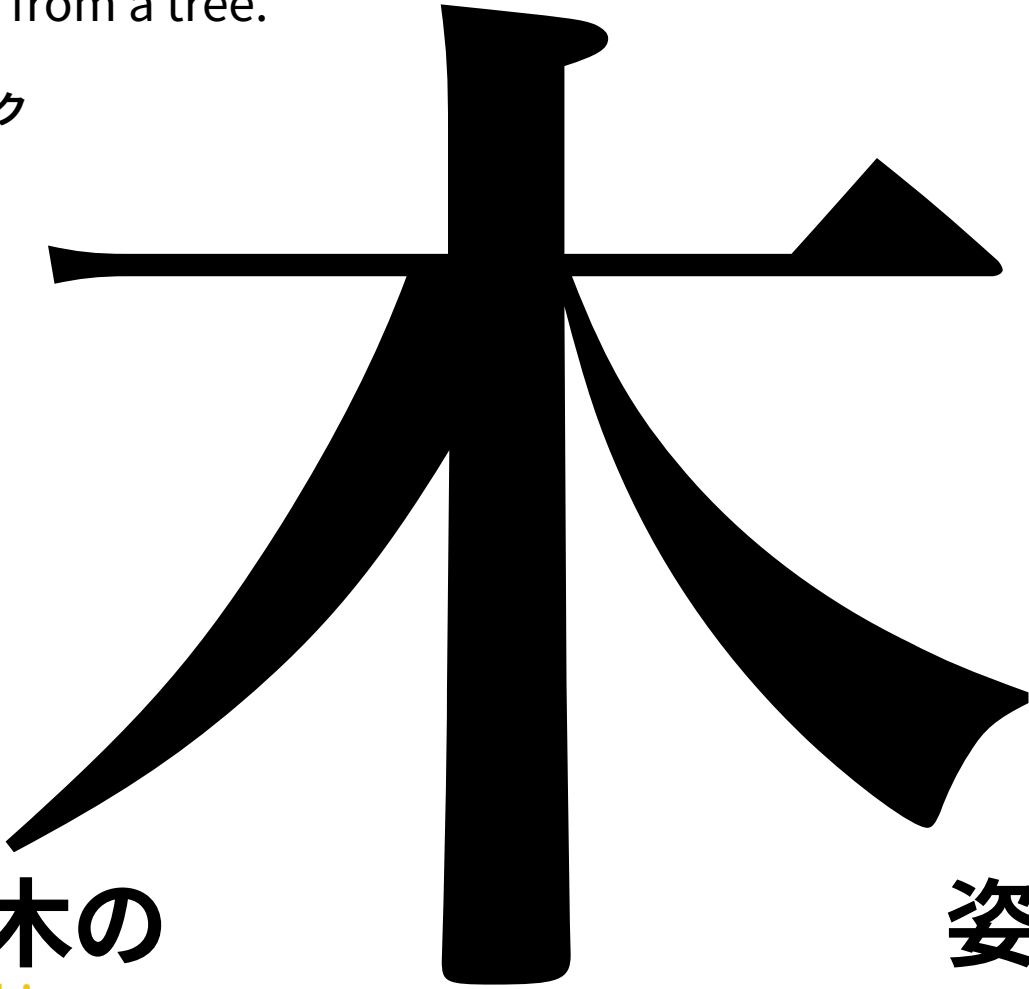
Tree; shrub; bush

今日隣の子が真っ逆様に木から落ちたのよ。

The boy next door fell
head first from a tree.

Kun: き、こ-

On: ボク、モク



櫪の木

kashi no ki no

姿かな

sugata kana

花にかまはぬ

hana ni kamawanu

Literal translation:

oak of tree of
flower to care not
a pose

Matsuo Bashō (1644–1694)

Japanese Trees

Japanese Red Pine

is native to Japan, Korea, and parts of China, and was introduced to the US in 1854. Its value lies in being a specimen tree due to its interesting form as well as its orange bark. It's also often used for bonsai.

Ginkgo

is a hardy, pest-resistant, and attractive large tree.

It has unusual fan-shaped leaves that turn vivid yellow in fall.

Only male trees should be purchased, as the females produce seeds with a soft, fruitlike covering that can be messy and have a potent odor.

Japanese red maple

is a tree that has been cultured intensively for over 300 years and retains a special place in the heart of all who love exotic trees. This little tree is the cornerstone of Japanese gardening, with its magnificent leaf color and shape.

Mizunara

is also known as Japanese oak (*Quercus crispula*) and is native to Hokkaidō, Japan's northernmost prefecture. It is one of the rarest and most expensive oaks in the world, and is often associated with luxury spirits. Just its name on a label can give prices a boost.

Cherry blossom

(桜, sakura) is Japan's unofficial national flower. It has been celebrated for many centuries and holds a prominent position in Japanese culture. There are dozens of cherry tree varieties in Japan, most of which bloom for just a few days in spring. The seasonal spectacle is celebrated with hanami (cherry blossom viewing) parties under the trees.

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History of Japanese

Japanese language, a language isolate (i.e., a language unrelated to any other language) and one of the world's major languages, with more than 127 million speakers in the early 21st century. It is primarily spoken throughout the Japanese archipelago; there are also some 1.5 million Japanese immigrants and their descendants living abroad, mainly in North and South America, who have varying degrees of proficiency in Japanese. Since the mid-20th century, no nation other than Japan has used Japanese as a first or a second language.

Japanese is the only major language whose genetic affiliation is not known. The hypothesis relating Japanese to Korean remains the strongest, but other hypotheses also have been advanced. Some attempt to relate Japanese to the language groups of South Asia such as the Austronesian, the Austroasiatic, and the Tibeto-Burman family of the Sino-Tibetan languages. Beginning in the second half of the 20th century, efforts were focused more on the origins of the Japanese language than on its genetic affiliation per se; specifically, linguists attempted to reconcile some conflicting linguistic traits.

An increasingly popular theory along that line posits that the mixed nature of Japanese results from its Austronesian lexical substratum and the Altaic grammatical superstratum. According to one version of that hypothesis, a language of southern origin with a phonological system like those of Austronesian languages was spoken in Japan during the prehistoric Jōmon era (c. 10,500 to c. 300 bce). As the Yayoi culture was introduced to Japan from the Asian continent about 300 bce, a language of southern Korea began to spread eastward from the southern island of Kyushu along with that culture, which also introduced to Japan iron and bronze implements and the cultivation of rice. Because the migration from Korea did not take place on a large scale, the new language did not eradicate certain older lexical items, though it was able to change the grammatical structure of the existing language. Thus, that theory maintains, Japanese must be said to be genetically related to Korean (and perhaps ultimately to Altaic languages), though it contains Austronesian lexical residues. The Altaic theory, however, is not widely accepted.



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Around the 8th century, as the Japanese language and culture began to flourish independently, a need arose to represent the sounds of the spoken language more accurately. This led to the creation of two new writing systems:

hiragana
and
katakana.

The origins of **hiragana** can be traced back to the “man’yōgana” system. In this system, Chinese characters were used to represent phonetic sounds rather than their original meanings. Initially, this system involved selecting specific Chinese characters that sounded similar to Japanese words. However, it was a complex and inefficient method that meant that literacy was limited to a very small scholarly class.

In the 9th century, during the Heian period, the script started to take shape as a simplified cursive text. Women of the Imperial Court, known as the “onnade,” played a crucial role in the development of **hiragana**. The women of the court were largely idle and had time to acquire a high level of education, something that required a writing system that was easier to use and suited the nuances of the Japanese language.

The onnade began modifying the man’yōgana characters, simplifying their shapes and emphasizing their phonetic values. This gradual transformation led to the creation of a distinct set of phonetic characters that were easier to write and more suitable for representing the Japanese language accurately.

Hiragana’s development was further influenced by the Chinese cursive script, known as “grass script” or “grass hand” (sōsho). The onnade incorporated elements of this cursive style into hiragana, resulting in its unique flowing and rounded appearance.

Hiragana initially consisted of about 90 different characters, which gradually decreased to the current set of 46 basic characters, known as “gojuuon,” during the 10th century. The gojuuon system organizes characters according to their syllabic sounds, starting with the five vowel sounds (a, i, u, e, o) and combining them with consonant sounds.

Throughout history, **hiragana** played a vital role in various literary works, particularly in the world’s first novel, “The Tale of Genji,” written by Murasaki Shikibu in the early 11th century. The novel showcased the potential and versatility of the new script.

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During the medieval period, **hiragana** became more widely used among the general population, particularly among women who were often excluded from learning Chinese characters. It provided a means for women to express themselves through writing, promoting literacy and communication in Japanese society.

The 17th century saw the introduction of katakana, a script used primarily for transcribing foreign words and onomatopoeic expressions. However, the older script maintained its importance as the script of choice for everyday writing, poetry, and informal communication.

With the advent of modernization and Western influence in the late 19th century, there was a movement to simplify and modernize the Japanese writing system. The government introduced a series of reforms known as the "script reforms" to simplify and standardize the use of **hiragana** and kanji.

Today, **hiragana** continues to be an integral part of the Japanese writing system, alongside kanji and katakana.

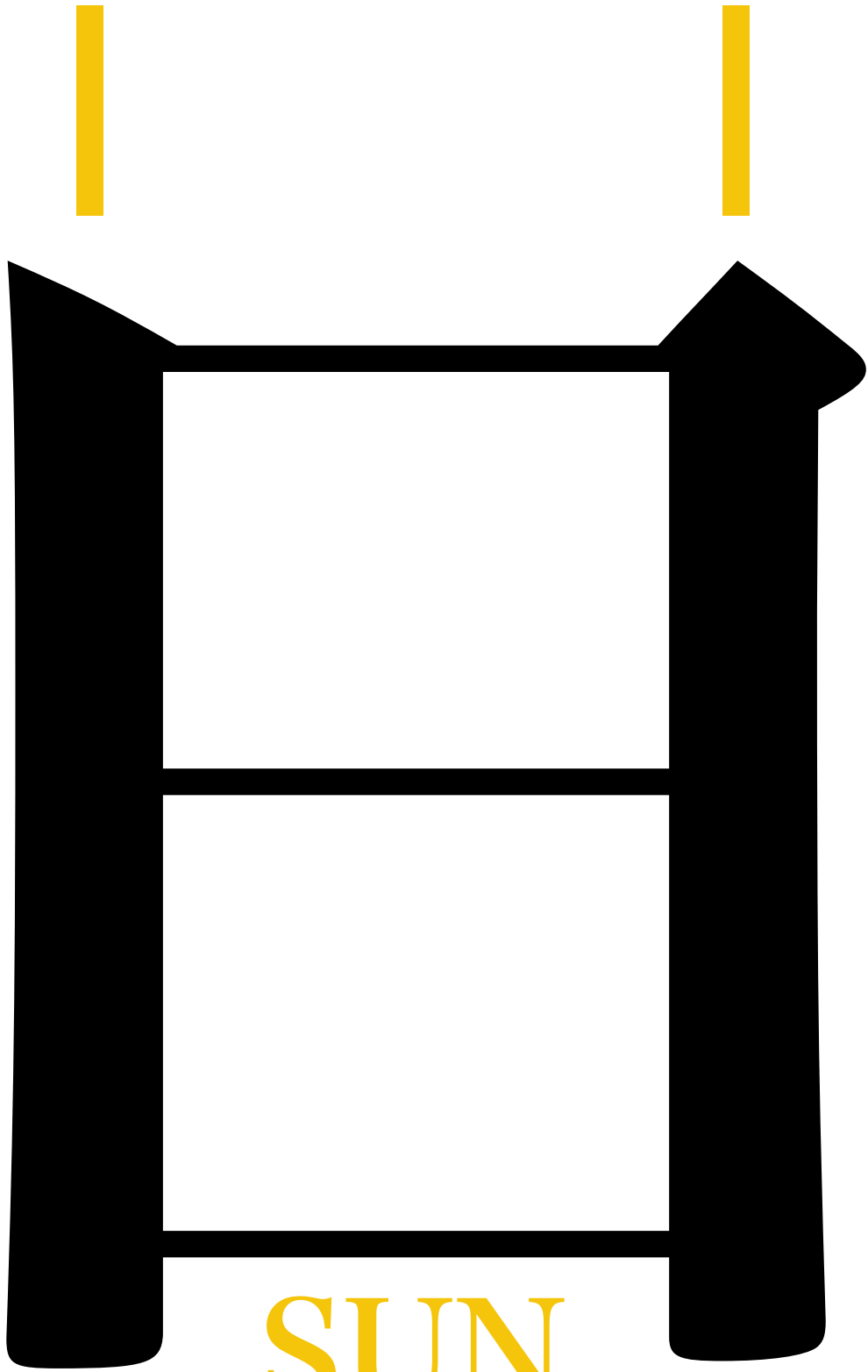
It is widely used for native Japanese words, verb conjugations, particles, and to provide furigana (phonetic guides) for kanji.

Hiragana is taught in the first year of school, and mastering it is essential for reading and writing in Japanese.

It has also become popular among non-native learners as a starting point for studying the language.

あ	い	う	え	お
か	き	く	け	こ
さ	し	す	せ	そ
た	ち	つ	て	と
な	に	ぬ	ね	の
は	ひ	ふ	へ	ほ
ま	み	む	め	も
や	り	ゆる	れ	ろ
ら	る	ん	ゑ	を
わ	ゐ			

The evolution of **hiragana** showcases the unique development of a writing system tailored to the phonetics and nuances of the Japanese language, while also reflecting the cultural and historical significance of Japan.



日蝕の盥にりと暑さ哉

a solar eclipse

a circle in a washtub...

summer heat

By Kobayashi Issa

日蝕の盥にりと暑さ哉

